after the launching of DF-21Ds on two occasions against the *Gerald Ford*. Similarly, the Chinese did not target US air and naval bases on Okinawa, Guam, Hawaii, or the Japanese main island of Honshu, even when the US Indo-Pacific Command began moving assets from those bases to the area of the campaign. Most surprisingly to US war planners, the PLA conducted relatively limited electronic warfare operations, perhaps out of fear that expansion of electronic warfare to the US mainland would result in similar attacks and significant disruption at home; moreover, US workarounds, primarily the ship-launched balloon communications network, partially blunted the effectiveness of China's initial electronic warfare salvoes. No satisfactory explanation was ever offered for the Chinese restraint, but suspicions remained rife that Xi Jinping was not willing to risk any domestic disruption that could mutate into anti-CCP movements, especially if the Americans could be checkmated early in the conflict.

Instead, each side limited itself to force-on-force encounters in the littoral seas and skies, confident of its ability to cripple the forward forces of the other and thereby impose an unacceptable cost in making the other commit further military assets. The United States did surge forces from Japan, Hawaii, and San Diego, but the Japan-based forces were checked at sea, while the Chinese decided to propose a cease-fire before US naval forces surged from Hawaii and San Diego could reach the combat zones. From a political perspective, Beijing was willing to cease combat operations to consolidate its significant gains, while the United States accepted its strategic losses and did not want to widen the war, which could have resulted in further defeats, especially once the effectiveness of the Chinese DF-21D and swarm missile attacks was proven. Instead, Washington decided that a reduced military presence in the region, centered on its alliances with Japan and Australia, was a better outcome than betting on the fortunes of war.

With each combatant willing, therefore, to limit future operations to preserve gains or prevent further loss, the political conditions were created for a geopolitical settlement that resulted in the emergence of the three blocs discussed in the previous section. Beijing concluded that